Prime numbers and Fermat's little theorem

Lecture and worked examples

Maths Explorer

Objectives

Recognise a prime number; prove that there are infinitely many primes; factorise an integer into primes and use the factorisation (divisors, gcd); use Fermat's little theorem to compute remainders.

Introductory activity

For an integer $n \geq 2$ and an integer a, let $r_n(a)$ be the remainder of a^{n-1} in the division by n.

Introductory activity (2)

1. Compute $r_5(2)$, $r_5(3)$, $r_7(2)$, $r_7(3)$ by hand, using congruences.

Introductory activity (3)

2. Using the Python function `pow(a, n - 1, n)`, which returns this remainder, complete the following table.

n	5	6	7	8	9	10	11
$r_n(2)$							
$r_n(3)$							

Introductory activity (4)

3. For which values of n do we get 1 on both rows? What do they have in common?
4. State a conjecture. Test it for $n = 13$ and $a = 5$.
5. For $n = 7$, compute $r_7(7)$ and $r_7(14)$. How should the conjecture be made more precise?

Introductory activity (5)

Observing is not proving: the properties conjectured here are established in the course.

Prime numbers

A natural number p is *prime* if it has exactly two positive divisors, 1 and p. Thus 1 is not prime.

Prime numbers

Every integer $n \geq 2$ has a prime divisor: its smallest divisor greater than or equal to 2. If n is not prime, this divisor p satisfies $p^2 \leq n$.

Prime numbers

Let p be the smallest divisor of n greater than or equal to 2 (it exists, since n is one). If p were not prime, it would have a divisor d with $2 \leq d < p$, which would also divide n: a contradiction. If n is not prime, $n = pq$ with $q \geq 2$ a divisor of n, so $q \geq p$ and $n = pq \geq p^2$.

Prime numbers

To know whether $n \geq 2$ is prime, it is enough to check that no prime p with $p^2 \leq n$ divides n. Example: 211 is divisible neither by 2, 3, 5, 7, 11, nor by 13, and $17^2 = 289 > 211$: 211 is prime.

Prime numbers

There are infinitely many prime numbers.

Prime numbers

Assume there are only finitely many: $p_1, \dots, p_k$. Let $N = p_1 p_2 \cdots p_k + 1 \geq 2$. By the previous theorem, N has a prime divisor, which is one of the p_i. This p_i divides N and the product $p_1 \cdots p_k$, so it divides their difference 1: this is impossible. The assumption is false.

Prime numbers

Cross out the multiples of each prime starting from its square; the numbers not crossed out are prime. lstlisting def crible(n): premier = [True] * (n + 1) premier[0] = premier[1] = False p = 2 while p * p <= n: if premier[p]: for m in range(p * p, n + 1, p): premier[m] = False p = p + 1 return [k for k in range(n + 1) if premier[k]] lstlisting There are 25 prime numbers less than 100.

Prime numbers

Let p be a prime number. If $p \mid ab$, then $p \mid a$ or $p \mid b$. More generally, if p divides a product, it divides one of the factors.

Prime numbers

If $p \nmid a$, then $\gcd(p, a) = 1$, because the only positive divisors of p are 1 and p. Gauss's theorem gives $p \mid b$. The case of a product of several factors follows by induction on their number.

Prime factorisation

Every integer $n \geq 2$ can be written as a product of primes, $n = p_1^{\alpha_1} p_2^{\alpha_2} \cdots p_k^{\alpha_k}$, with $p_1 < p_2 < \cdots < p_k$ prime and $\alpha_i \geq 1$. This expression is unique.

Prime factorisation

Existence, by strong induction. The integer 2 is prime. Assume every integer in $\{2, \dots, n\}$ can be factorised. If $n+1$ is prime, we are done; otherwise $n+1 = ab$ with $2 \le a, b \le n$, and we put the factorisations of a and b together.

Uniqueness. If $p_1 \cdots p_r = q_1 \cdots q_s$ (repeated prime factors), p_1 divides the product of the q_j, hence one of them, which is prime: $p_1 = q_j$. We cancel and start again; the two lists of factors coincide.

Prime factorisation

Divide by the smallest divisor $p \geq 2$ as long as possible; it is prime. When $p^2 > n$, the remaining quotient, if it exceeds 1, is prime. lstlisting def decomposition(n): facteurs = [] p = 2 while p * p <= n: while n % p == 0: facteurs.append(p) n = n // p p = p + 1 if n > 1: facteurs.append(n) return facteurs lstlisting For example, `decomposition(360)` returns `[2, 2, 2, 3, 3, 5]`.

Prime factorisation

If $n = p_1^{\alpha_1} \cdots p_k^{\alpha_k}$, the positive divisors of n are the integers $p_1^{\beta_1} \cdots p_k^{\beta_k}$ with $0 \leq \beta_i \leq \alpha_i$. There are $(\alpha_1 + 1)(\alpha_2 + 1) \cdots (\alpha_k + 1)$ of them.

Prime factorisation

The gcd of two integers is the product of the common prime factors, each raised to the smaller of the two exponents. Example: $360 = 2^3 \times 3^2 \times 5$ and $84 = 2^2 \times 3 \times 7$ give $\gcd(360, 84) = 2^2 \times 3 = 12$.

Fermat's little theorem

Let p be a prime number and a an integer. Then $a^p \equiv a \pmod{p}$. If moreover p does not divide a, then $a^{p-1} \equiv 1 \pmod{p}$.

Fermat's little theorem

Step 1. For $1 \leq k \leq p-1$, p divides $\binom{p}{k}$. Indeed $k\binom{p}{k} = p\binom{p-1}{k-1}$, so $p \mid k\binom{p}{k}$; since $1 \leq k < p$, p does not divide k and $\gcd(p,k) = 1$; Gauss gives $p \mid \binom{p}{k}$.

Step 2. By the binomial formula, for every integer a,
$(a+1)^p = a^p + \sum_{k=1}^{p-1} \binom{p}{k} a^k + 1 \equiv a^p + 1 \pmod{p}$.

Fermat's little theorem (2)

Step 3. Induction on $a \geq 0$: $0^p \equiv 0$, and if $a^p \equiv a$, then $(a+1)^p \equiv a^p + 1 \equiv a + 1 \pmod{p}$. For $a < 0$, choose an integer $b \geq 0$ such that $b \equiv a \pmod{p}$; then $a^p \equiv b^p \equiv b \equiv a$.

Step 4. If $p \nmid a$, then $p \mid a^p - a = a\left(a^{p-1} - 1\right)$ and $\gcd(p, a) = 1$; Gauss gives $p \mid a^{p-1} - 1$.

Fermat's little theorem

Remainder of 3^{2026} in the division by 11: 11 is prime and does not divide 3, so $3^{10} \equiv 1 \pmod{11}$. Since $2{,}026 = 10 \times 202 + 6$, $3^{2026} \equiv 3^6 = 729 \equiv 3 \pmod{11}$ (because $729 = 66 \times 11 + 3$).

Fermat's little theorem

The converse is false: $2^{340} \equiv 1 \pmod{341}$, whereas $341 = 11 \times 31$.